Reducing Small Boat Arrivals

Where should the UK focus upstream interventions?

Recommendation

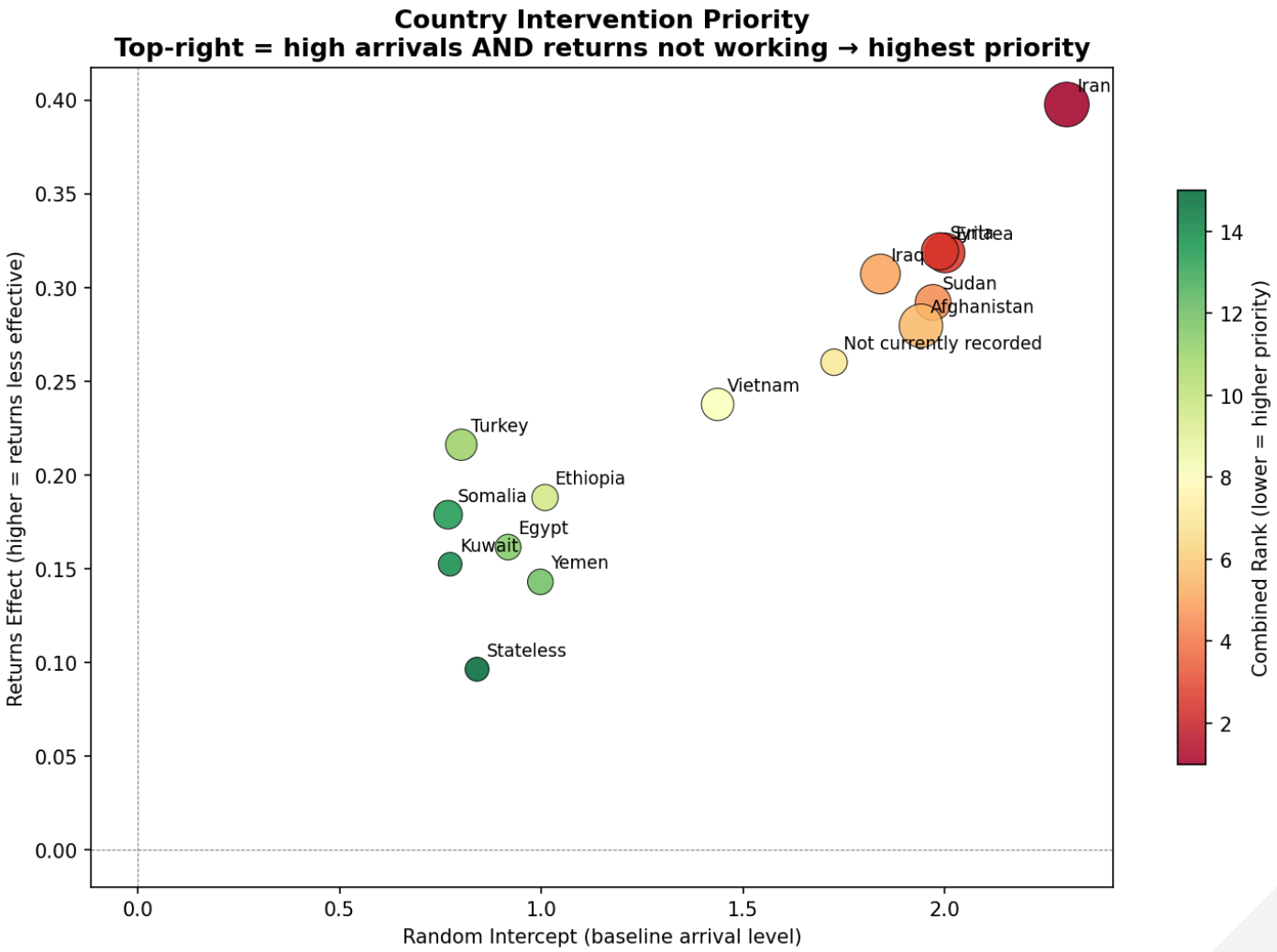
*Match the **type of intervention** to each country's migration profile.*

Country	EU27 Detections	UK RouteShare	Intervention
Iran	95,590	20.4%	Source + bilateral deal
Eritrea	57,855	17.4%	Bilateral / transit deal
Sudan	42,430	16.3%	Bilateral / transit deal
Vietnam	38,495	12.2%	Bilateral / transit deal
Afghanistan	468,215	3.6%	Multilateral / EU burden-sharing
Iraq	187,205	8.8%	Source + bilateral deal

Iran, Eritrea, Sudan, and Vietnam **disproportionately target the UK** — bilateral deals directly reduce UK arrivals. Afghanistan and Syria mostly reach other EU states — pursue **multilateral burden-sharing**.

Which countries should be prioritised?

- **Top-right** = high arrivals AND ineffective returns — highest priority
- **Iran** is the clear #1, followed by Eritrea, Syria, Sudan, and Iraq



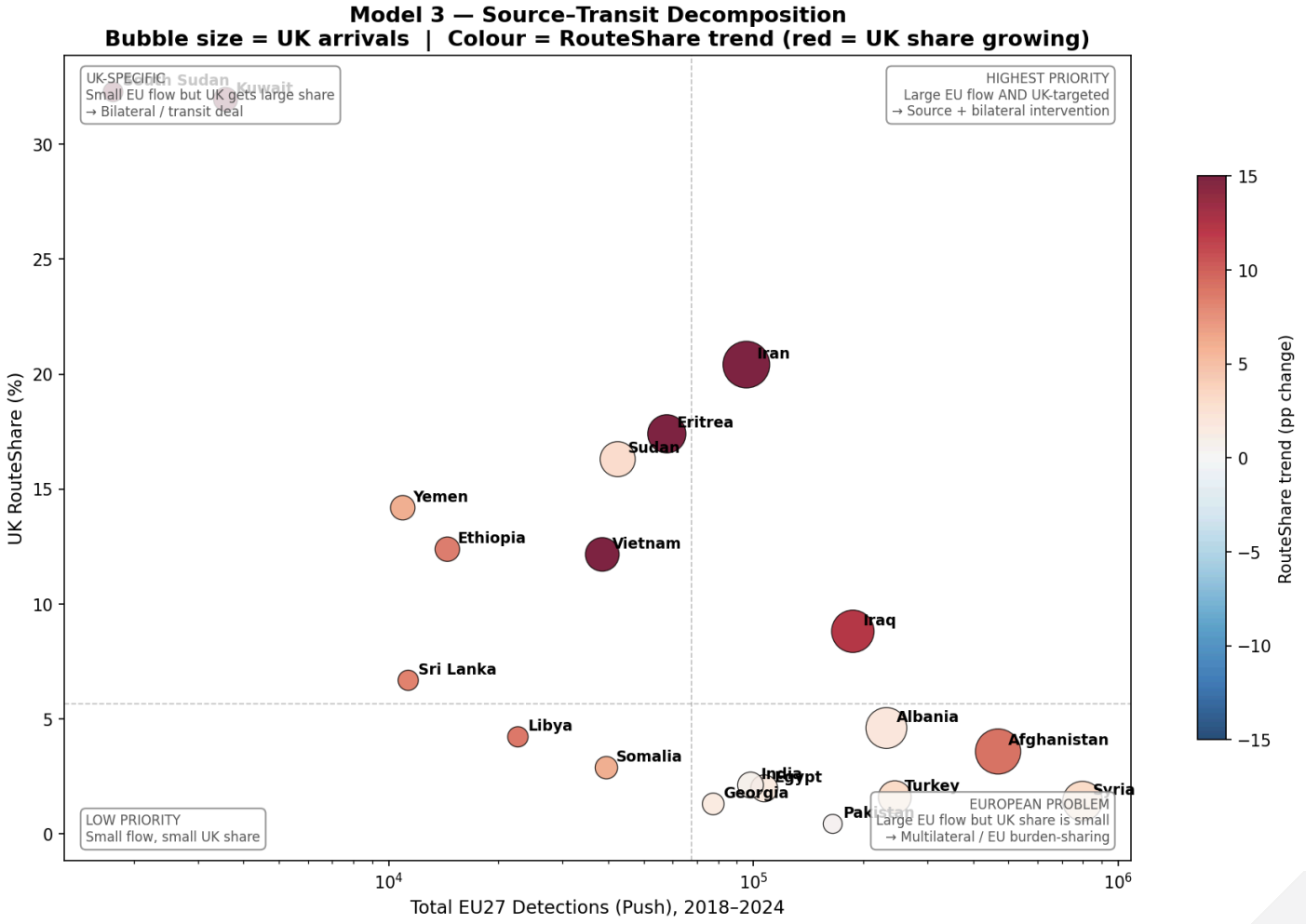
Source vs transit: where should the UK intervene?

Not all countries require the same type of deal. Comparing UK arrivals to **EU-wide flows** reveals whether a nationality is a UK-specific problem or a broader European one.

Nationality	UK Arrivals	EU27 Detections	UK RouteShare	Intervention
Iran	25,780	95,590	**20.4%**	Source + bilateral
Afghanistan	22,667	468,215	3.6%	Multilateral / EU sharing
Iraq	17,521	187,205	8.8%	Source + bilateral
Eritrea	11,552	57,855	**17.4%**	Bilateral / transit deal
Sudan	8,201	42,430	**16.3%**	Bilateral / transit deal
Vietnam	6,996	38,495	**12.2%**	Bilateral / transit deal

The policy quadrant

- **Top-right**: large EU flow AND UK-targeted — highest priority
- **Top-left**: small EU flow but high UK share — bilateral or transit deals
- **Bottom-right**: large EU flow but low UK share — multilateral burden-sharing



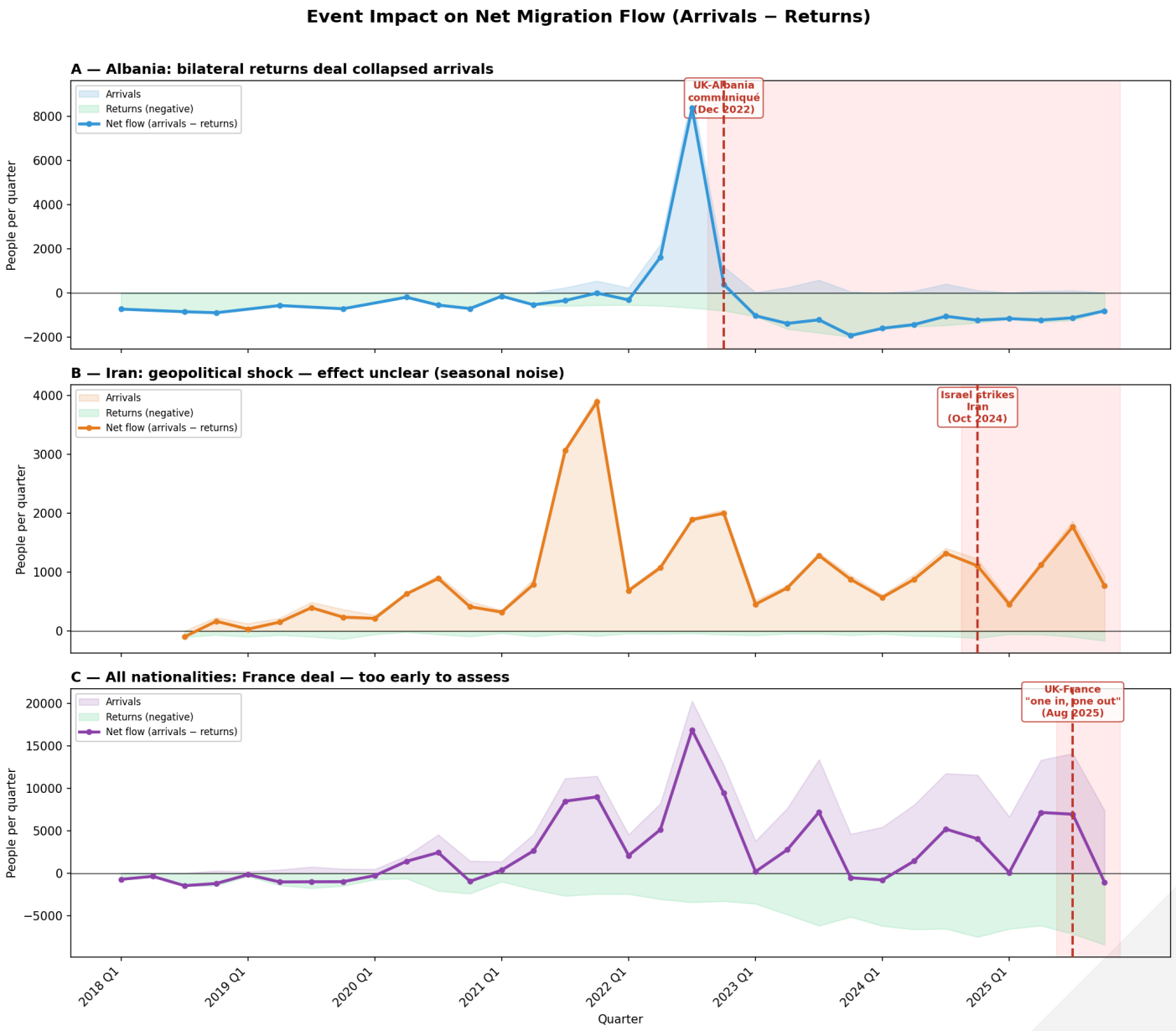
What does this mean?

- **Iran, Eritrea, Sudan, Vietnam** have high UK RouteShare (**12–20%**) — these nationalities disproportionately target the UK. Bilateral agreements would directly reduce UK arrivals.
- **Afghanistan and Syria** have very low RouteShare (**<4%**) — the vast majority go to Germany, Sweden, and France. Source-country interventions benefit Europe broadly but the UK captures only a small share of the gain.
- **Vietnam's UK share is growing fastest** (+31pp since 2018), signalling an emerging UK-specific route that warrants urgent attention.

> *The UK should pursue **bilateral deals** with Iran, Eritrea, Sudan, and Vietnam, and seek **multilateral burden-sharing** on Afghanistan and Syria.*

Do interventions work? Evidence from real events

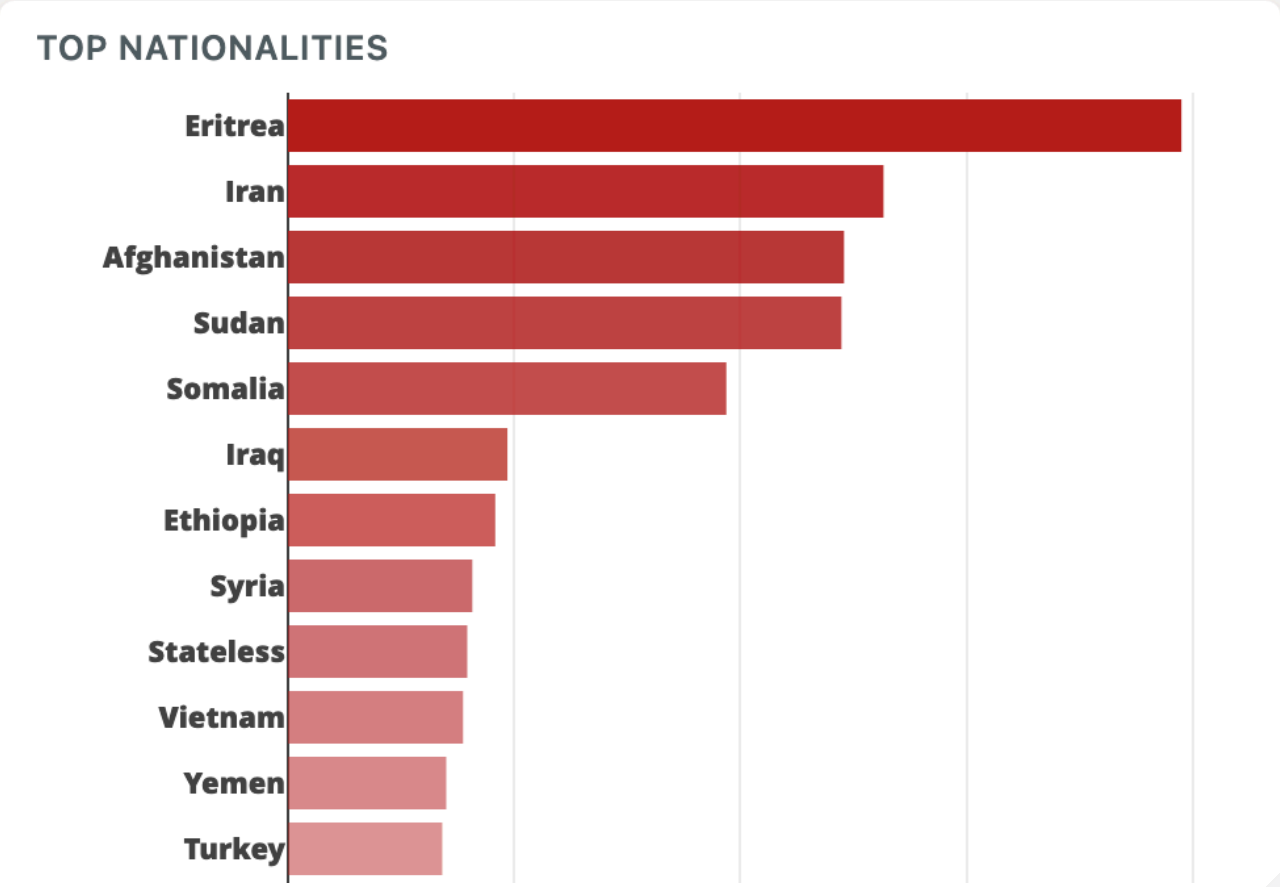
- **Albania deal** (Dec 2022): arrivals collapsed from 3,000/qtr to 500; net flow flipped **negative**
- **Israel strikes Iran** (Oct 2024): no clear effect on Iranian migration
- **France "one in, one out"** (Aug 2025): too early to assess — only 2 quarters of data



Appendix: Exploratory Data Analysis

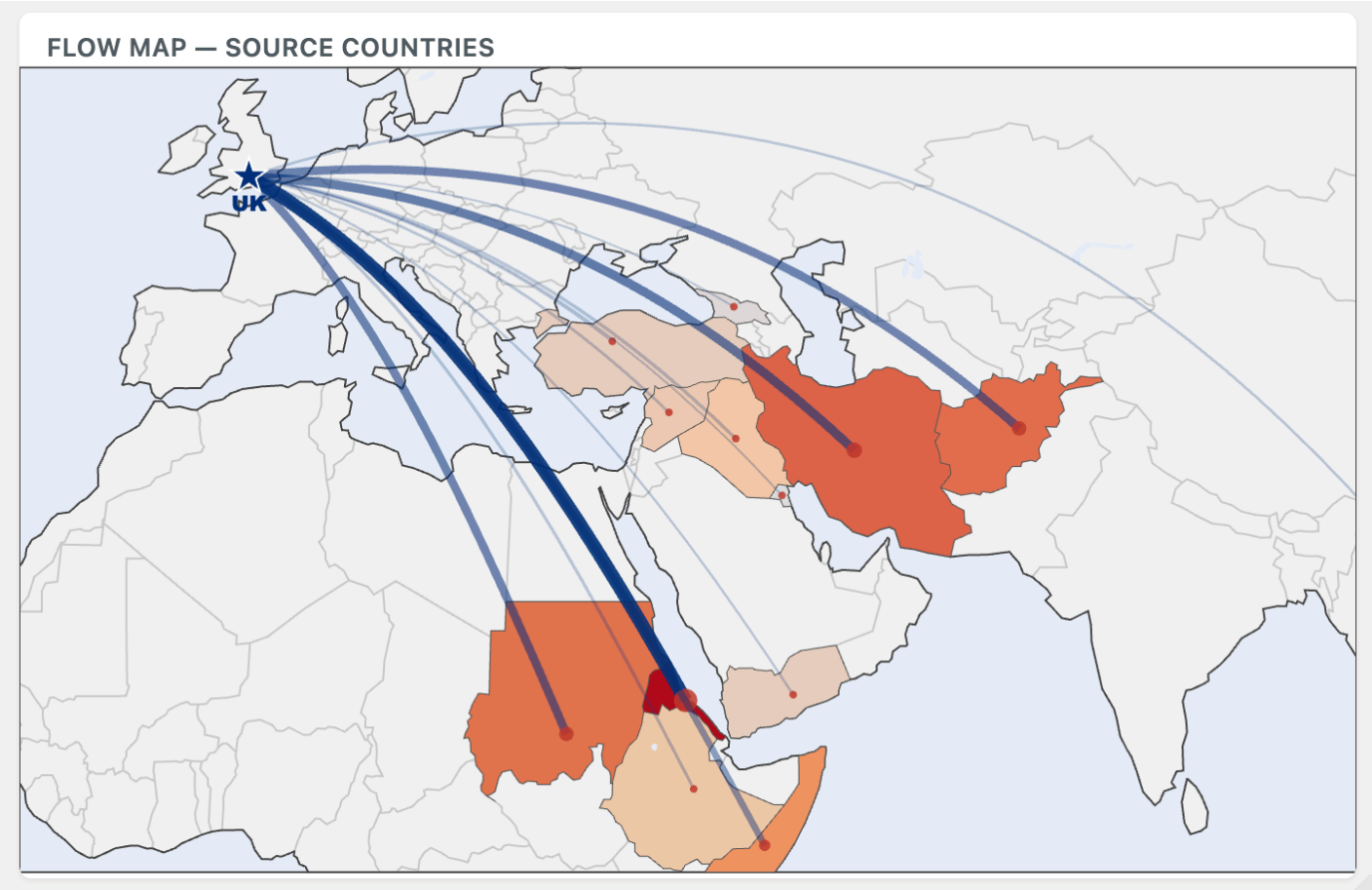
Who is arriving? Top source countries (2025)

- **Eritrea** has overtaken Iran and Afghanistan as the #1 nationality
- Top four account for **49%** of 46,497 detections



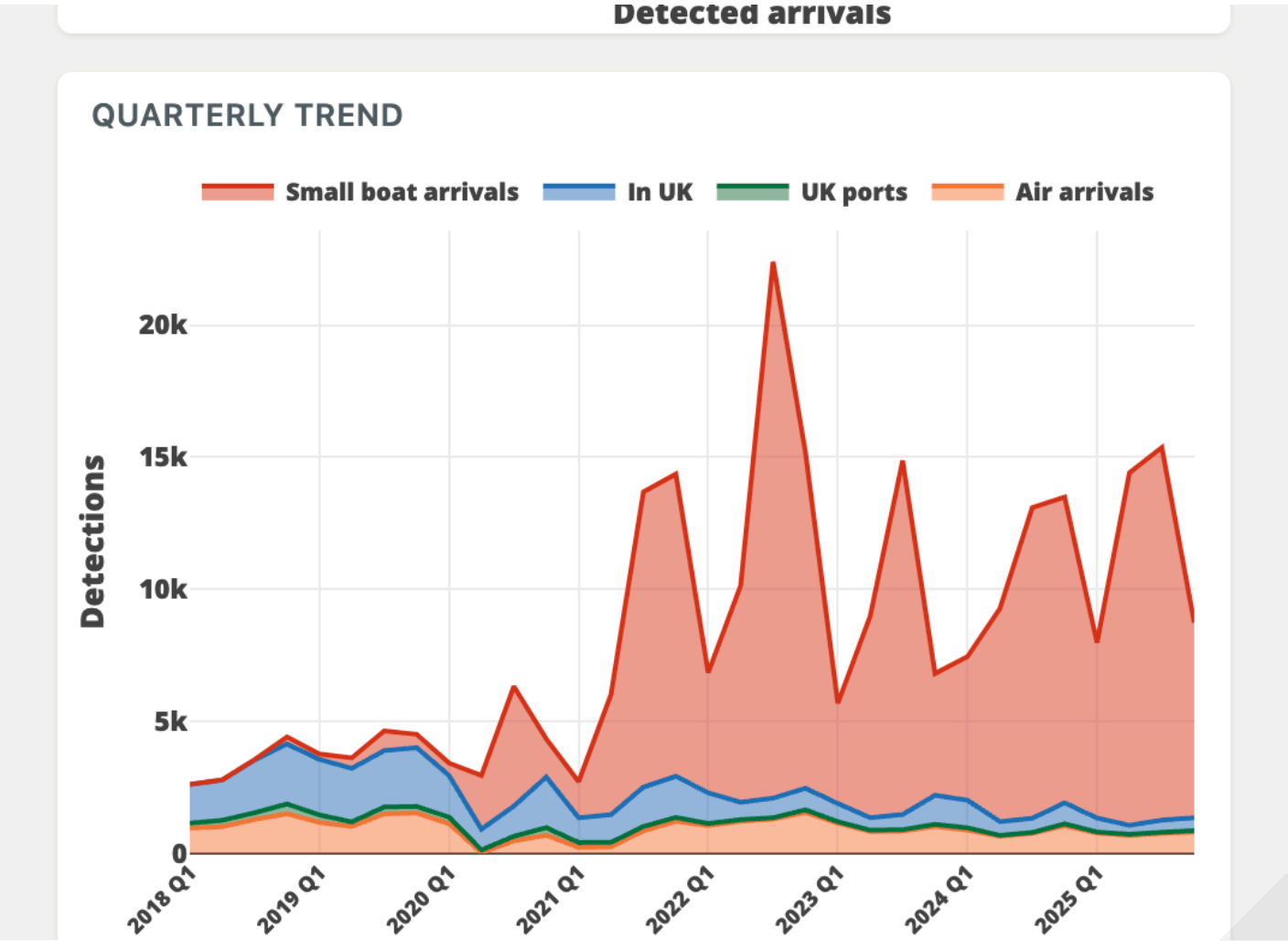
How do they reach the UK? Routes & transit countries

- Sources cluster in the **Horn of Africa** and **Middle East**, transiting via **Turkey** and **Libya**



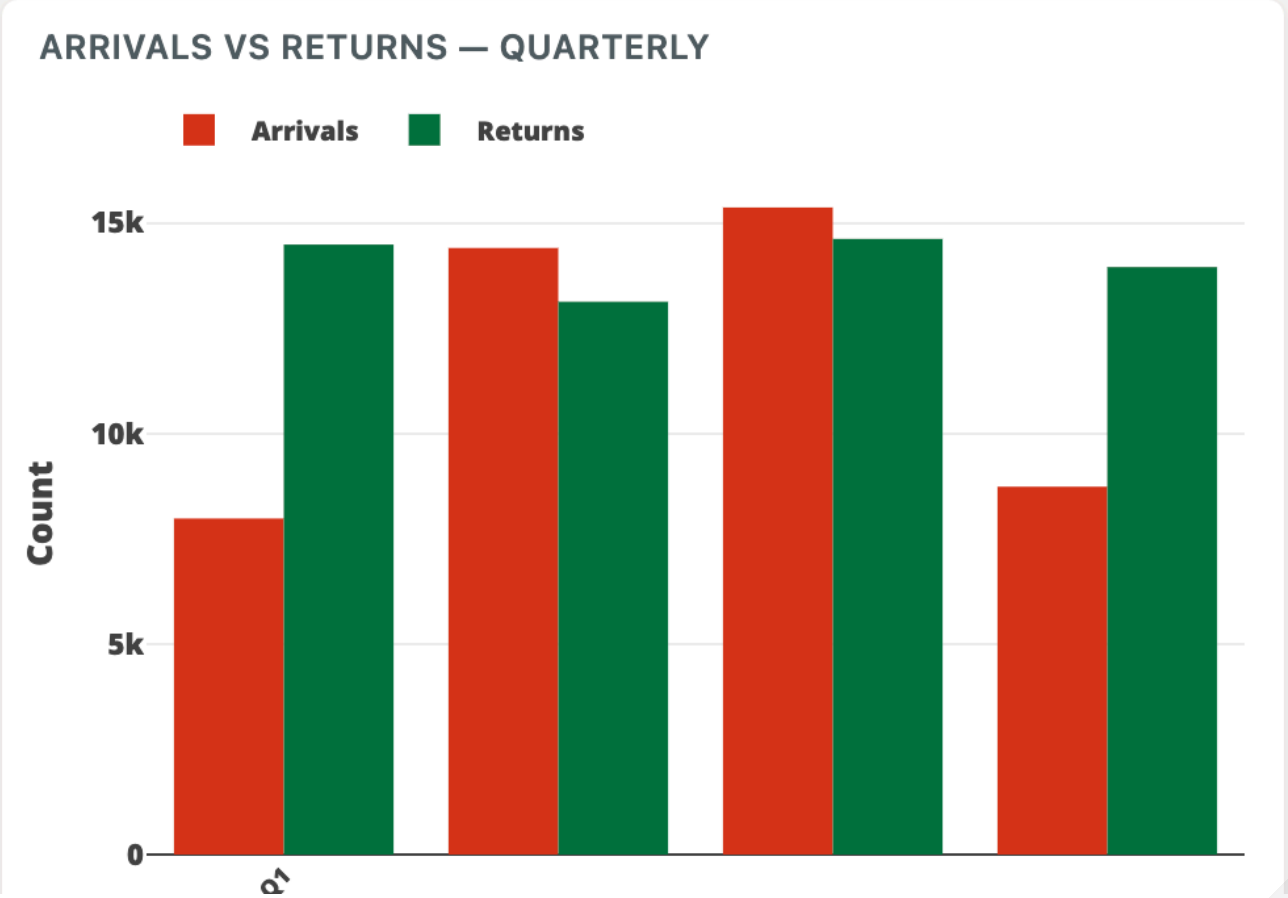
How are flows changing over time?

- Small boats = **89%** of entries; peaked 2022, **rebounded** in 2024–25
- Horn of Africa nationals (Eritrea, Sudan, Somalia) are rising fast



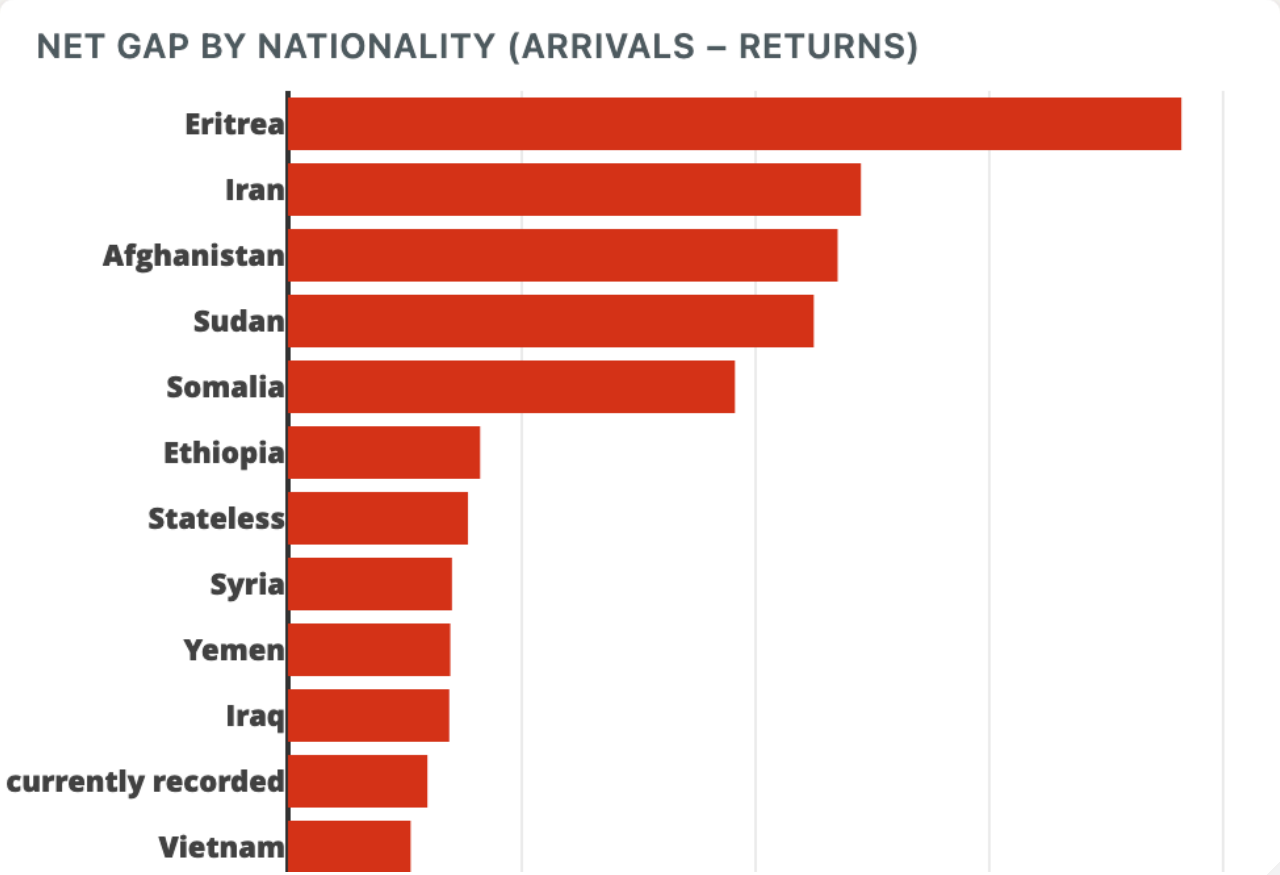
The returns gap

- In 2025: **56,197** returns vs **46,497** arrivals — net **–9,700**
- But returns are mostly **visa overstayers and FNOs**, not small boat nationalities



Where are returns failing?

- **Eritrea, Iran, Afghanistan, Sudan** — high arrivals, virtually zero returns
- These are where **returns agreements would have the greatest impact**



Thank You

Explore the data: chri4354.github.io/april-repo

Questions?